

FOOTBALL'S FUTURE BECOMES ITS PRESENT

NINE YEARS AFTER THE FIFA U-17 WORLD CUP INTRODUCED INDIAN FANS TO FOOTBALL'S **NEXT GENERATION**, 18 OF THOSE TEENAGERS ARE NOW REPRESENTING THEIR COUNTRIES AT THE 2026 FIFA WORLD CUP, UNDERLINING HOW ONE YOUTH TOURNAMENT BECAME THE LAUNCHPAD FOR THE GAME'S NEW STARS.

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Nine years ago, the first FIFA tournament hosted in India offered a glimpse into football's future.

Packed stadiums in New Delhi, Kolkata, Kochi, Navi Mumbai, Goa and Guwahati watched teenagers chase their dreams.

Many have since disappeared into the game's vast, unforgiving talent vortex.

Yet, 18 of those youngsters are now back on football's biggest stage, representing their countries at the 2026 FIFA World Cup.

No nation has produced more graduates than Japan. Five members of Hajime Moriyasu's squad, Keito Nakamura, Takefusa Kubo, Zion Suzuki, Yukinari Sugawara and Ayumu Seko, first experienced FIFA competition in India.

Among the 18 players to have made that remarkable leap, none has, so far, left a greater mark on this World Cup than Nakamura, who has a goal and an assist to his name.